Hydrocephalus

Hydrocephalus is a buildup of fluid on the brain, which can damage brain tissue. It is caused by excess cerebrospinal fluid or by fluid not draining away normally. Acquired and normal-pressure hydrocephalus are the two adult-onset forms, but it can also occur in children.

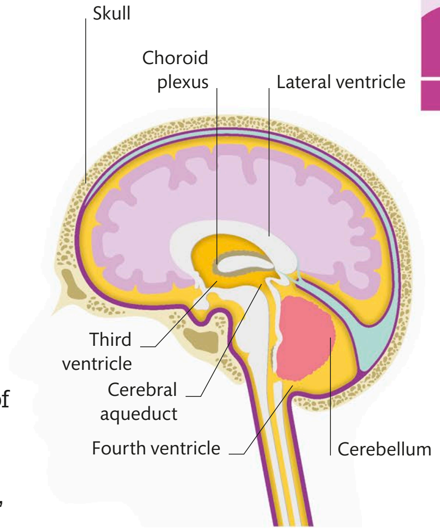
Acquired hydrocephalus is caused by damage to the brain after stroke, hemorrhage, a brain tumor, or meningitis. Enlarged brain cavities fill with excess cerebrospinal fluid (CSF) or block areas where fluid is reabsorbed into the bloodstream.

Causes of other forms

The cause of normal-pressure hydrocephalus is often unknown, but it might be due to underlying health conditions such as heart disease or high cholesterol.

The main symptoms are usually headache, nausea, blurred vision, and confusion.

In children, hydrocephalus can develop after a premature birth, bleeding on the brain, or in cases of spina bifida. In babies and young children, symptoms include a swollen head, but in older children, the disorder might show up as severe headaches. Damage caused by the pressure can lead to loss of developmental skills, such as walking and talking.



Fluid on the brain
CSF is created by the choroid plexus, a cellular membrane lining brain ventricles, or cavities. If it isn't reabsorbed, it pressurizes the brain, causing hydrocephalus symptoms.

Narcolepsy

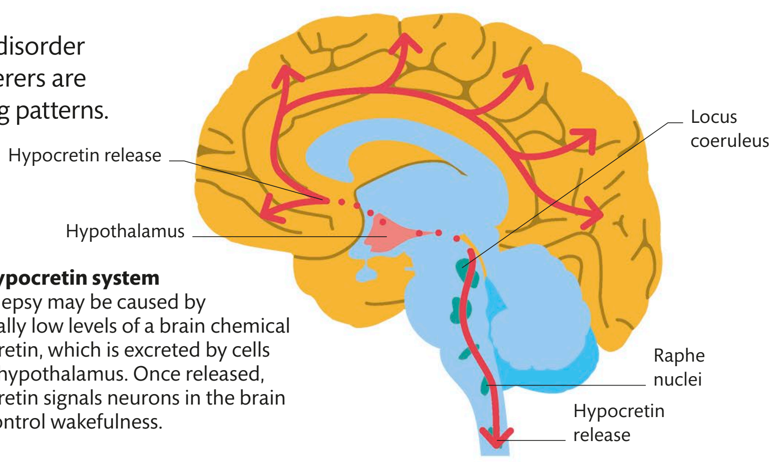
Narcolepsy is a rare, long-term neurological disorder characterized by sudden bouts of sleep. Sufferers are unable to regulate normal sleeping and waking patterns.

Narcolepsy usually starts around puberty and affects both sexes equally. Symptoms include excessive daytime sleepiness, falling asleep suddenly, and sometimes performing tasks but having no memory of doing so.

The condition can include sleep paralysis—a temporary inability to move or speak, accompanied by terrifying nightmares. Sleep deprivation is a common side effect.

Cataplexy

Around 60 percent of sufferers are classed as Type 1, which means they also have cataplexy.



The hypocretin system
Narcolepsy may be caused by unusually low levels of a brain chemical hypocretin, which is excreted by cells in the hypothalamus. Once released, hypocretin signals neurons in the brain that control wakefulness.

A cataplexic person experiences weakness in muscle control in response to strong emotions such as humor, anger, or pain. There is no loss of consciousness, but sufferers may collapse as a result of loss of muscle tone and are usually unable to speak or move.

CATAPLEXY CAN BE TRIGGERED BY AN EMOTIONAL REACTION SUCH AS **LAUGHTER**